



Voices Across the Digital Divide

Using audio portals to connect communities.

Human beings are the only species on earth with the ability to communicate complex ideas through language. Speaking and listening have been the basis of human society since people started living in communities. In fact, the words ‘community’ and ‘communication’ share a common etymology.

Democracy, as a system, is completely dependent on communication, to the extent that when communication breaks down, so does the democratic process. In order for a group of people to participate equally in democracy, they must necessarily share a communication platform, where they can share not just facts, but also views and opinions. Small wonder then, that free speech is prized and cherished by all democracies, and coveted by citizens of almost all countries that are yet to become democracies.

One of the fundamental requirements of free speech and participation in democracy is the availability of a free, open medium and platform of communication that is equally accessible by all members of the democratic community. Almost every culture in the world has a concept of a central community gathering place, where people gather after a day's work, to talk and share

information. In India, this is typically the village *chaupal*, in West Kalimantan (erstwhile Borneo), Indonesia, it's called a *ruai*. In Afghanistan, it may be called a *chaikhana*. These community structures have traditionally provided the common platform and free medium for communication. This type of platform is structured like a circle, and the free medium is air. In a circular structure, everyone has an equal say, because everyone has equal access to the medium and equal reach to every other member of the platform. No special equipment is required to use this medium; ears and a mouth will typically suffice. These structures provided a way for people to voice their opinion, share their concerns and find solutions to conflict through dialogue.

After the industrial revolution and the dawn of the corporation, mass media began to play this role in people's lives. Newspapers, radio and television became the new media that people used. These media had a much wider reach and they seemed like the perfect democratic tool. However, these media have a structural problem that prevents them from being truly democratic. By virtue of corporate and editorial hierarchy, these media are structured like a triangle (Figure 1). News, in this model, travels